

Cooler Initiative

Going to jail was never so educative. Or relaxed, as this unique experiment of turning a historical prison into a recreational place for the public shows so well.

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A MAKEOVER WITH A HISTORICAL FLAVOUR

| By Stephen David |

When BJP leader L.K. Advani visited the old Bangalore Central Jail last fortnight, he did not expect his brief home during the infamous Emergency to have metamorphosed into a well landscaped public park. Advani, like many other Opposition politicians, had spent several months in the century-old Bangalore Central Jail. After the 22-acre jail became overcrowded, the S.M. Krishna government moved the inmates to a new site. The Bangalore City Corporation then set out to develop the Freedom Park with Rs 17.35 crore to provide open space to the public and maintain its historical character.

Legislator Dinesh Gundu Rao, whose constituency Gandhinagar covers the 150-year-old jail area, fought hard to create these lungs for the choked state capital. Rao said: "We are glad that the public will finally get to see how a jail looked like—in a comfortable setting." The old prison barracks, which used to house 100 prisoners at a time, have been retained. So have the hospital blocks, the central tower and entrance block in their original condition as these are heritage buildings. Even the

old watch tower with its wooden beam ceiling and the old turret is a landmark. Dog-eared archives include a handwritten letter by Mahatma Gandhi.

A landmark of India's freedom struggle, it is now a multi-use urban park offering 10 acres of garden space and play area. Also available are hi-tech information counters and facilities for cultural programmes and leisure. Another highlight of the Freedom Park is a five-acre dedicated space for demonstrations as in London's Hyde Park. It also includes a sculpture court, a 250-seat amphitheatre, an open-air art gallery and a café.

Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa said: "Creating new open spaces like Cubbon Park or Lalbagh for a city which will house eight million people is a tough task but we plan to free up existing spaces." Next in line is the sprawling Race Course facing the park. Other plans include a sound and light show similar to the one at the Cellular Jail in Port Blair. "Visiting an old jail will be a learning experience," says corporation commissioner S. Subramanya. Now on its way to being a major tourist attraction, going to jail could not have become cooler than this. ■